

Showing Off Trends

Digit visited Taipei, Taiwan, to attend the Computex Taipei 2004 exhibition. The biggest brands, the best products, read all about it here...

A few days into our Taipei visit, a fellow journalist commented that Taiwan's handloom industry must be LCD panels. Tongue-in-cheek for sure, but there is an element of truth in that statement. LCDs are everywhere, and in every form. Consider a cab we hired—it had an LCD TV nestling just above the gearbox and blaring news in Mandarin, while the rear-view mirror sported a mini-LCD panel which served as a compass. This was in a cab!

Early into our visit, we learned that Taiwan acts as a manufacturing hub for the IT industry. Almost everything electronic under the sun is made between Taiwan and China. Taking the LCDs as an example, AUO, the third largest manufacturer of the panels, took us around its assembly plant. In went their LCD panels, and out came Thompson LCD TVs and Dell LCD monitors.

It was no surprise that Computex 2004 is a business-to-business show; a place for company X to show off its manufacturing capability to OEM Y, and gain a contract to build its branded system or to use its parts. Computex was all about components—everything from microdrives to PC cabinets. Though there were some finished products, they were few and far between.

The show did serve to highlight trends within the industry. The biggest being convergence, and the oft-repeated mantra of the digital home. It seems more obvious with each passing event, that the PC is not going to be sidelined by consumer devices. Indeed, WenChi Chen, VIA Technologies' President and CEO,



With an 8.4-inch TFT LCD and an Intel XScale 400 MHz processor, the Weblet offers around eight hours of normal usage and up to two weeks on standby

was of the opinion that key PC technologies would migrate into the heart of everything consumable—TVs, personal recorders and handheld devices. Some of this was apparent: USB connected plush toys which moonlighted as MP3 players, portable MPEG4 video players with microdrives, telephones with wireless LAN support (802.11a/b/g); some sporting CCD cameras and TFT LCDs for video-conferencing, LCD TVs which doubled up as monitors; an MP3 player with a photo viewer that is also an MPEG4 player with TV output, and a card reader and a bootable drive as well—try saying that in one breath. Also, if Taipei and the show serve as an indication, cameras—both still and video—will soon be everywhere. Everywhere!

The concept of the digital home was also more grounded at Computex. There were no refrigerators with built-in computers, instead computers posed as various consumer devices. Prominent amongst these were the media centers.

Small Form Factor (SFF) PCs are in-the-mini-ITX motherboards, and low-power processors make for tiny, but sufficiently powerful PCs. Prominent amongst the SFF solutions was the MSI MEGA 180—a small cube, resembling a music deck from the pre-MP3 eras and little buttons to push on its face, and the coolest colour-LCD display with dancing lights. Oh, sweet nostalgia!

As a consumer device, it supports instant-on CD/Radio and MP3 playback with 5.1-channel sound, powered by nVidia's nForce2 chipset. As a computer, it has inbuilt Wi-Fi (802.11b), an Ethernet port, a 56K modem, dual-VGA out, two USB 2.0 ports, two Firewire ports, a six-in-one media card reader, and the much-salivated-after nVidia Soundstorm-Dolby Digital capable. All this powered by an AMD Athlon XP 3000+ processor, two DIMM slots upgradeable to 2.0 GB of DDR 333, 1 AGP 8X slot and 1 PCI slot. The optional TV-tuner card allows for all the standard PVR func-



The Revolution is a laptop that swivels into a Tablet PC, powered by an Intel PIII processor. What sets it apart from similar solutions is a rugged industrial design with a classy magnesium chassis and C-Span construction to protect the interior against shocks